

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Awakening: Life from Death

The Bible: Book of Science, Rules, Facts, Myths or Life?
Easter tide 5

May 25th, 2025



Umbria primavera, 1945 - Gerardo Dottori

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on KINGSFOLD
Bicinium on LLANFAIR (John Barr)
Voluntary on VICTORY (Robert Lind)
TRURO (Edwin T. Childs)
Meditation on VILLE DU HAVRE (Elizabeth Krouse)
MFURAHINI, HALELUYA (Anthony Giamanco) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Sarah Fuhrmiester

In this season of Eastertide,
we have taken a leap in order
to communicate the Good News
for our time and place.

We stand in a long line of those who have gone before –
people who went out on a ledge
to bring a Spirit that was, and is, still active and speaking.

John the Baptist did it early with his daring and new river ritual
with no temple priesthood to support him.
Paul did it with his independent letters,
when there was no apostolic authority
to assure or reassure him.
Jesus did it with the Judaism of his time and place.

This is the only pattern available to us
in the humble and willingly fallible world of faith,
and yet, it is how we each tentatively contribute
our little part to the great truth of God.

Only future history will know whether ours
was a good or bad teaching.
That is how we all live in the faith of our own
moment in time,
and we must continually be in the process of
handing ourselves over to God's
always, larger future. [adapt/richardrohr]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Deep in the Shadows of the Past

KINGSFOLD

Deep in the shadows of the past, far out from settled lands,
Some nomads traveled with their God across the desert sands.
The dawning hope of humankind by them was sensed and shown:
A promise calling them ahead, a future yet unknown.

While others bowed to changeless gods, they met a mystery:
A hidden, uncompleted Name, "I am what I will be";
And by their tents, around their fires, in story, song, and law.
They praised, remembered, handed on, a past that promised more.

From Abraham to Nazareth the promise changed and grew,
While some, remembering the past, recorded what they knew.
And some, in letters and laments, in prophecy and praise,
Recovered, kindled, and expressed new hope for changing days.

For all the writings that survived, for leaders, long ago,
Who sifted, copied, and preserved the Bible that we know,
Give thanks and find its story yet our promise, strength, and call:
The working model of our faith, alive with hope for all.

-lyrics by Brian Wren NCH

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

You have given us your Word, O God,
and sometimes, we think we can keep your Word bound
in a dusty book, safe and harmless.

But you are a God who will not be bound,
a God who breaks all binding.
So on this day, we ask for help in letting go
of that which binds us to beliefs we have turned into stone,
and now have become harmful
to the legacy of your living Word, Holy One.

Beginning today, O God, open us to a relationship
with the stories of those who have gone before us.
And in the days to come, Holy One,
open us to encounter you anew.

We pray this in the name of the One we follow.
Amen and Amen!

[adapt/sbeton]

***Introit**

"My Lord, What A Morning"
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

TRADITIONAL NEGRO SPIRITUAL
arr. HENRY THACKER BURLEIGH

***The Lord's Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmiester

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people.
This day, tonight, and forever.
Amen and Amen!*

[John Philip Newell]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

This morning we have gathered once again
to hear the stories of our faith,
*about God's mighty acts, about the brave deeds
of prophets and heroes, of disciples and ordinary
people who lived out a commitment to God.*

We seek to immerse ourselves in the stories of faith,
*by striving to find our role within it,
by interpreting it anew as it touches our spirits and
circumstances, and by allowing it to change us.*

We hope to be ongoing participants in the stories of our faith,
as translators of love into action,
as creators of justice and peace,
as characters who confront life
with a true sense of devotion.

*In this time, may we listen deeply
to God and to each other,
as we share the stories of this unbounded faith.*

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the First Epistle of John

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Sarah Fuhrmiester

For the Word of God in Scripture.
For the Word of God within us.
For the Word of God among us.
Thanks be to God.

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People
Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Silence

Prayers of Our Hearts

Holy One, in this season of new life,
we are coming to believe
that death is not the end,
but rather a transformation
into new possibilities.

We are learning
that nothing that exists
is ever completely destroyed.
A star exploding
or a leaf falling:
both offer new possibilities
and will 'live on'
in ways unknown to stars and leaves.

As winter has given way to spring
and as summer calls to us more each day,
what once seemed lifeless
now abounds with life,
and with new possibilities and delights.

Help us, Ever-Changing One,
to also experience
new possibilities
arising from our failures
or disappointments
or what has come to an end.

*We give thanks on this day
for all the influences in our lives
that have helped us see beyond the present
and that continually call us to live in hope and in trust.*

*On this day, we offer this in the Way of the One
we choose to follow.
Amen and Amen!*

Meditation Anthem

"Kyrie" from Misa Criolla
Lorenzo Zapata and Frank Hobbs, *Soloists*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

ARIEL RAMIREZ

Sermon

The Bible: Book of Science, Rules, Facts, Myths or Life?

Rev. Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

This is a table of blessing, of sharing, and of celebration.

We break bread and pour the fruit of the vine
because these are the gifts that strengthen our journey together.

We remember how on many occasions Jesus took bread, offered a blessing,
and then shared the bread with his friends saying,
'My love for you will never end.'

We also remember how Jesus poured out the fruit of the vine,
offered a blessing and passed the cup among those same friends saying,
'Remember your love for each other will be the greatest gift.'

These were times of uncertainty, of conversation, and of celebration,
and after Jesus' death they would be remembered
in ways that helped those friends to see
the bread, and the fruit of the vine, as symbols
of how we are all interconnected,
and that life can come from death
through the giving and receiving
of the simple things of this life, we share.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Nearer My God To Thee"
Christin Byrdsong, *Soloist*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

JAMES L. STEVENS

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

O Presence and Power within us,
Being and Life of all,
how we are filled, how we overflow
in this place with love and goodness.

On this day, and with these offerings,
O God, let us sow grace and peace,
and show mercy to all,
through acts of gentle loving-kindness.

As those who seek to live
with a clear and honest vision,
we commit ourselves.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

To being the Body of the Word of God
in this time and place,
and to being open
to the Spirit of New Life
in our lives and in our world
we say...
May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.

For the journey that has been,
for all that life is for us now,
for all our future stories hold,
and for the mystery
that brings life from death
we say...
Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

“Let The Sun Shine In” from *Hair*

GALT MCDERMOTT

Christin Byrdsong and Frank Hobbs, *Soloists*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

*Hymn for the Journey

Holy Mystery

AUSTRIAN HYMN

Holy Mystery, Holy Wisdom wholly Love who guides our way,
Loving Presence, Source of Being, now transform us day by day.
Words of Scripture tell our stories, voices rise in gifts of song,
Calling us to loving action, faith-filled as we journey on.

See the streams of living waters, springing from eternal love,
Wells supplying all that matters, and all fear of want remove;
Who can faint while such a river ever flows their thirst t’assuage?
Grace, which like our God, the giver, never fails from age to age.

We are partners in creation, bound by love to all around,
Seeking justice and compassion, sharing truths that we have found.
Spirit, source of inspiration, love our song along the way,
Holy Mystery, Holy Wisdom – source of hope with each new day.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Short Prelude and Fugue in F Major (ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Inside The Music

“Our music today helps us consider our relationship with known texts and ideas. We begin with the traditional Negro Spiritual *My Lord, What a Morning*, arranged by H.T. Burleigh, whose work in arranging Negro spirituals was pivotal in educating 20th century North American culture in the music of the Enslaved: his legacy acknowledging that Negro Spirituals were inherently protest songs and active forms of resistance, a reclamation of humanity, coded communication towards freedom, and a refusal of the Enslaved to be stripped of voice, culture, identity, and spirit.

Both our introit and meditation anthems address God as “Lord”, the use of which is a subversive one: a radical claim challenging societal hierarchical powers of authority. Declaring Jesus as “Lord”, or, as in our meditation anthem by Argentinian composer Ariel Ramirez “Kyrie” or “Señor”, contests the idea that earthly rulers have any authority or power, and calls for a reorientation towards God’s divinity, which is fair, just, and equitable. The use of the word “Lord” is not in compliance or submission to harmful and abusive feudal systems of power, but in direct subversive refusal of them!

In offertory, we sing an arrangement of the traditional hymn *Nearer my God to Thee* which was composed as a musical illustration of Jacob’s relationship with God: a new recognition of God’s closeness to him in the present. In James Stevens’ arrangement of the hymn, the choir sings of this paradoxical nearness: “Guide Us, God, to the highest places through the narrow paths. This is how we go to the stars, higher.” In choral response, we sing Galt McDermott’s protest song *Let the Sun Shine in* from his theatrical war protest piece *Hair*. Each song of the four today guiding us toward the notion that the fairness and equity of God is the ultimate protest.” -Dr. Ianthe Marini